

Sport and Sailplanes

Some impressively aerobatic designs dated from the 1940s, but sports planes were high-risk products for manufacturers in the litigious 1990s. As a result many of them resorted to selling aircraft as kits or even just sets of plans, in the hope that home builders would blame themselves if the machines broke up in flight. Gliders became sleeker and faster in this decade, while microlights became more practical for covering longer distances instead of just local flying.



△ **Stolp SA-300 Starduster Too 1990**

Origin USA

Engine 180 hp Lycoming O-360 air-cooled flat-4

Top speed 180 mph (290 km/h)

Designed in the 1960s, Lou Stolp's homebuilt sport biplane, normally with two open cockpits, had wood/metal structure, fabric/fiberglass-covering, and was capable of mild aerobatics.



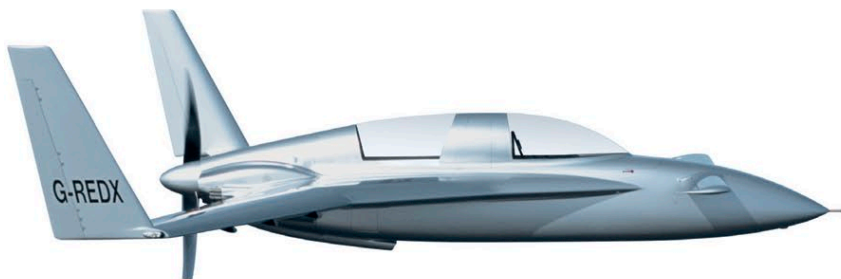
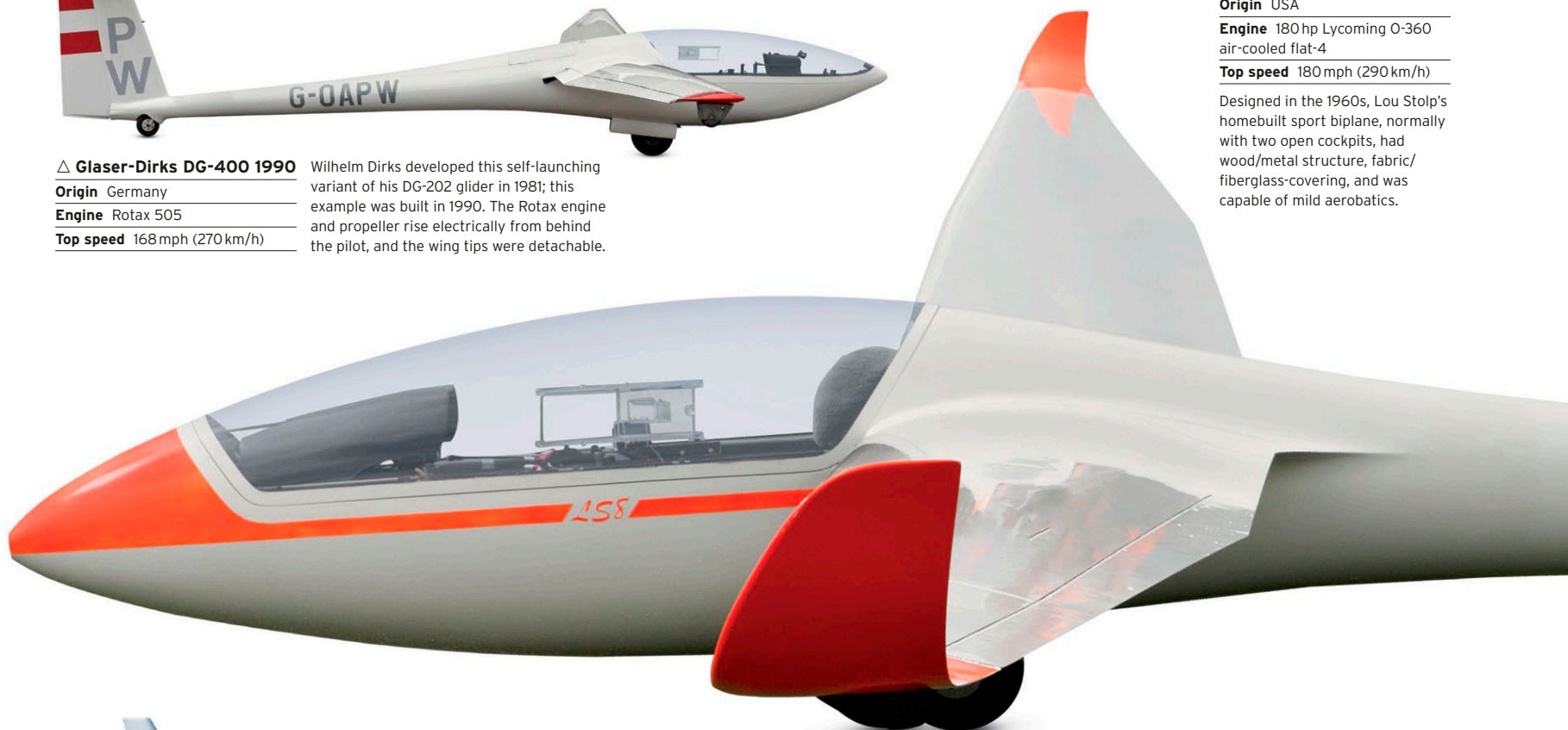
△ **Glaser-Dirks DG-400 1990**

Origin Germany

Engine Rotax 505

Top speed 168 mph (270 km/h)

Wilhelm Dirks developed this self-launching variant of his DG-202 glider in 1981; this example was built in 1990. The Rotax engine and propeller rise electrically from behind the pilot, and the wing tips were detachable.



△ **Berkut 360 1990**

Origin USA

Engine 205 hp Lycoming IO-360 air-cooled flat-4

Top speed 248 mph (399 km/h)

This tandem-seat canard built mostly of carbon fiber and fiberglass bankrupted designer Dave Ronneburg and passed through several makers; in all 20 were built and around 75 were sold as kits.



△ **Extra 300 1990**

Origin Germany

Engine 300 hp Lycoming AEIO-540 air-cooled flat-6

Top speed 197 mph (317 km/h)

Designed by aerobatic pilot Walter Extra, with a roll-rate of around 400 degrees per second and g-limits of +/-10, the 300 is one of the most potent aerobatic aircraft in the world. It is still a favorite of airshow pilots and aerobatic champions.



◁ **Sukhoi Su-29 1991**

Origin USSR

Engine 360 hp Vedenyev M-14P air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 183 mph (294 km/h)

This excellent aerobatic performer was based on the single-seat Su-26, and is virtually able to hang on its propellers as well as pull g-limits of +12 to -10. Extensive use of composites made it light and strong.